

1C We're really busy right now

SPEAKING OUTPUT | a work-based discussion

GOAL | agree on the best way to fix a work problem

MEDIATION SKILL | inviting contributions

WARM-UP

1 Work in pairs and discuss the questions.

- How do you prefer to contact companies: by phone or by the chat service on their website?
- When you call a company, what kind of automated messages do you often hear while you're waiting to talk to someone?
- Is there anything you don't like about the experience of contacting customer service on the phone?
I don't like the music. It's really annoying.

PREPARE

2 **MB1.01** | Read the Scenario and listen to the messages. Why does Janel want to talk about the automated message system?

SCENARIO

Janel sends you this message:

Hi everyone.  

I looked at our feedback yesterday and everybody hates our automated messages on the customer service system! It has a rating of two stars out of five and people say it's really unfriendly and annoying. Can you listen to it and have a look at the script (see below) and think about how we can change it? Then we can talk about it in next week's meeting.

Thanks!
Janel

Automated message

You've got through to Well Gym. Press 1 to book a personal trainer. Press 2 to book the pool. Press 3 to speak to someone.

[If no one is free to help the customer when they choose an option:]

We're really busy right now. Continue to wait or maybe call back later. While you're waiting, why don't you leave us a five-star review online?

[Music plays: heavy rock]

[Repeat message every 15 seconds.]

3A **MB1.02** | Listen to three people discussing the messages. What problems do they discuss?

- the person's voice
- too many options
- the music
- the content of the messages

B **MB1.02** | Listen again. Which things (1–4) does Janel do to help her colleagues give their opinions?

- say how the conversation will be organised
- ask people's opinions
- say something funny to help everyone relax
- ask people to say something about other people's opinions

4 Read the Mediation Skill box. Which phrases did Janel use? Listen again and check.

MEDIATION SKILL

inviting contributions



When you are trying to solve a problem in a group, it is good to organise the conversation so that everyone has a chance to share their ideas. Here are a few ways you can do this.

Say how the conversation will be organised
Can we share one idea each about how we can change this?

Let's talk about the music first, then we can talk about the messages.

Ask the whole group

OK, what does everyone think?

How do we feel about these ideas?

Ask individuals

Lesley, **what are your thoughts on it?**

Rich, **how do you feel about Lesley's idea?**

Ask people to build on other people's opinions

Rich hates the music – **what are your thoughts on it, Lesley?**

I think the guy's voice is a bit boring. **What does everyone else think?**

5 Complete the conversation with sentences from the Mediation Skill box.

Janel: So, we've got two possible plans to fix the problem. ¹.....?

Lesley: I think plan A is better, it's cheaper and easier to do.

Janel: ².....

Rich: I think Lesley's right, it is easier.

Janel: OK, so Les and Rich think plan A is better. ³.....? Tom? Chris?

6 Look at the Scenario again. Make some notes about how you can make the message more friendly and less annoying.

MEDIATE

7 Work in groups. Discuss the issue from the Scenario and decide how you will improve the system.